



▲ **NO ONE'S FLOCK** Chandrika Pal, a Gadariya from Bhishampur village, is part of the OBC mix here. Strong local competition with the more dominant Yadavs governs his vote

those named cannot contest, falling as they do on the wrong side of the Dalit-tribal continuum (Gonds are ST all over Robertsganj; Kharwars are ST in Sonbhadra, SC in Chandauli).

As a case study of thwarted enfranchisement—of representation controlled and diminished through tokenism at the very point where it is conferred—Robertsganj is a classic. The outgoing MP, Pakaudi Lal Kol, was a good chess piece for the Apna Dal (Sonelal) president, Union minister Anupriya Patel: the Kol vote is substantial in her own neighbouring constituency, Mirzapur. All the flora gathered in the BJP's composite bouquet by 2019—dominant castes, backwards, non-Jatav Dalits—would help the National Democratic Alliance (NDA) partner swim through anyway in Robertsganj. Pakaudi Lal happened to mess up that neat piece of electoral landscaping, hurling imprecations at Brahmins and Thakurs from a public stage in 2021 and earning their ire for good.

Dalits and Adivasis together form nearly 40 per cent of the heterogeneous population in Robertsganj. But a 'coalition of the oppressed' is not how it works out

Divide and Rule

So this time's candidacy was hanging till the end: Pakaudi Lal was a no-no, but the fear of upsetting her own Kol voters finally forced Anupriya to field his bahu Rinku. The Samajwadi Party has opted for Chhotelal Kharwar, the one who won in 2014 under a BJP flag (Pakaudi Lal, then with the SP, had come third). The Chamars, therefore, are faced with a dilemma: whether to go for the lone Chamar hopeful, advocate Dhaneshwar Gautam of the Bahujan Samaj Party (BSP), or with 2024's larger caste realignments and vote INDIA (Indian National Developmental Inclusive Alliance). In short, for the largest Dalit group in an SC reserved seat, the choice is between fragmentation and surrogate fulfilment.

Variations of this pattern play out nearly universally, with rare exceptions. The majority Dalit choice is systematically annihilated in seats created specifically to allow their choice to prevail. Mostly through division. "The Dalit vote is frequently rendered even more irrelevant in reserved seats; in general seats, they are at least a factor," says Yadav. On the ground, it produces something like a paralysis of the democratic will—and a strange leadership vacuum. "Politics in these seats has evolved in a way that favours token faces," says Koppula Raju, head of the Congress core team. "And there is no incentive for the other castes because these are reserved seats."